RAVN DESIGN · ROUND ROBIN · ENGINEERING TRACK

Vello NeighborCard

Design Fidelity Audit

Adriana · September 2026

AI generates. Verification makes it faithful.

WHAT CLAUDE GENERATED

It renders. It drifts.

The first version looked fine at a glance.
Property by property, almost everything was wrong.

3 CATEGORIES OF ERROR

WRONG ANATOMY

Initials instead of photos. Generic Lucide icon instead of Vello's custom shield SVG. One star instead of five. MapPin instead of Footprints.

MISSING STATES + DATA

No Available badge. Only one distance format instead of three. Rating as a number without stars. Simplified data shape.

ACCESSIBILITY

 instead of <button>. No keyboard navigation. Chevron announced to screen readers. Stars without aria-label.

THE MOST VALUABLE ARTIFACT

The guardrail improved with every failure.

CLAUDE.md — the rules file that tells Claude what tokens to use, what data shapes to follow, and what not to skip. It got more specific every time the output failed.

4 ITERATIONS

v1 — Weak guardrail

6 raw colors + "don't invent." Claude complied technically but drifted semantically. Used hex values, wrong icons, no states.

v2 — Semantic tokens + data contracts

Required var(--surface-card) not #FFF. Photos not initials. Native shield SVG. Structured distance data with 3 formats.

v3 — Accessibility + interaction states

<button> not . 44px targets. Focus ring. aria-hidden on chevron. aria-label on stars. prefers-reduced-motion.

v4 — Integration rules

Use Vello's native nb classes. Don't create overlays or demo surfaces. The card must look like another neighbor in the list.

CORRECTED COMPONENT

Three real product states, semantic tokens, accessible



State 1: Available + featured
Verified, green badge, photo, bio, 5 stars, distance pill



State 2: Not available
No badge — user knows they exist but aren't free right now



State 3: Perfect rating
All 5 stars filled, available, verified

DESIGN FIDELITY AUDIT

What got fixed

TOKEN DRIFT (7 PROPERTIES)

Card surface: #F6F2E7 → var(--surface-card)

Available badge: coral (--accent) → green var(--brand-primary) + var(--surface-brand-tint)

Verified mark: Lucide icon → native shield SVG

Rating stars: hardcoded amber → var(--rating)

Distance pill: div → pill with var(--border-default)

Text hierarchy: one ink → --text-strong, --text-body, --text-muted

Focus ring: Tailwind outline → box-shadow: var(--focus-ring)

ACCESSIBILITY (5 FIXES)

Root element: <div onClick> → <button type="button">

Chevron: no aria → aria-hidden="true"

Rating: no label → aria-label="Rated 4.9 out of 5"

Photo: no alt → alt={neighbor.name}

Distance: walk only → walk, blocks, mi as separate fields

QUESTIONS FOR THE DESIGNER

1. Card elevation: shadow-md, shadow-brand, or none?

2. Available badge: now uses --brand-primary (green). Confirmed correct?

3. Unavailable state: hide card or show without badge?

4. Shield mark: var(--brand-primary) or verification-specific token?

AI generates fast.
Fidelity comes from verification.

The most valuable artifact wasn't the code.
It was the guardrail — and it's reusable.

What engineering contributes isn't just implementing —
it's catching when a card that "looks similar" has the wrong photo,
the wrong icon, the missing states, and the incomplete data.